

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr C Pulger

Address: 11 Kings Road Belmont SM2 6DG

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer objects to the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I wish to formally object to the proposed redevelopment of the former ambulance station to a Place of Worship and Community Hub.

While the inclusion of community facilities is acknowledged, the scale and intensity of this proposal are fundamentally incompatible with the quiet, residential character of the surrounding neighbourhood and the safety requirements of the adjacent primary school. The proposal conflicts with national planning policy objectives that seek to promote safe, healthy, and well-functioning places.

Impact on Highway Safety and School Pupils

The proposed change to a high-capacity Place of Worship (Use Class F1) and Community Hub (Use Class F2) will result in a significant increase in vehicular movements. The surrounding residential streets already experience considerable congestion and traffic stress during school drop-off and pick-up periods. The addition of congregational traffic would exacerbate these conditions, creating unsafe bottlenecks and increasing risks to young pedestrians.

This is contrary to the National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF), which requires development to provide safe and suitable access for all users and to ensure that highway safety is not compromised. Paragraphs 110 and 111 of the NPPF make clear that development should only be permitted where safe access can be achieved and where the residual cumulative impacts on the road network would not be severe. In this case, the proposal fails to demonstrate that it would not result in unacceptable risks to highway safety, particularly for schoolchildren.

Furthermore, the provision of cycle storage and refuse facilities indicates a level of occupancy that the existing narrow residential road infrastructure is not designed to safely accommodate.

Loss of Residential Amenity

The residential environment in this location is particularly sensitive to noise and disturbance. The proposed mixed-use development would attract large numbers of users simultaneously. Noise arising from increased footfall, vehicle movements, car doors, and congregational activity-potentially occurring during early mornings and late evenings-would result in an unacceptable loss of residential amenity for neighbouring properties.

This directly conflicts with paragraph 135 of the NPPF, which states that development should be sympathetic to local character and should not create unacceptable impacts on the living conditions of existing residents, including from noise and disturbance. The proposal fails to demonstrate how these impacts would be adequately mitigated.

Overdevelopment and Massing

The proposed part-one, part-two storey extensions and overall increase in building height represent an over-intensification of the site. The increased scale and massing would appear visually overbearing and out of keeping with the surrounding residential context.

This is inconsistent with paragraph 130 of the NPPF, which requires development to respond positively to local character, maintain a strong sense of place, and ensure that buildings are visually attractive and appropriate to their surroundings. The proposal fails to achieve these objectives.

Failure to Achieve Sustainable Development

Taken as a whole, the proposal does not meet the NPPF's core objective of achieving sustainable development. Paragraph 8 of the NPPF makes clear that social sustainability includes supporting health, safety, and quality of life. A development that increases risk to children, harms residential amenity, and undermines community cohesion cannot be considered socially sustainable.

Overall, the proposal fails to demonstrate that it can operate without compromising the safety of schoolchildren or the reasonable enjoyment and tranquillity of nearby homes. For these reasons, the development should be refused.

It is also evident that a significant number of local residents have raised objections to this proposal, indicating a clear lack of community support. Should planning permission be granted despite this overwhelming opposition, there is a strong likelihood that the decision-making process and consultation procedure would be subject to scrutiny. Such an outcome risks causing substantial disappointment, undermining confidence in the planning system, and damaging community cohesion.